

FAT SAM

There's a version of me that most were unaware of. One I was trying to move on from.

Most people who've worked alongside me have no idea that version ever existed. And that's by design.

Something I learned over the years is that a kitchen is the only place where no one gives a fuck about your past. You find school dropouts, misfits, immigrants—some of which may or may not be legal—ex-criminals. None of it matters.

As long as you can cook.

I'm not the social type. Avoided small talk like it was the plague. Didn't want anyone knowing about my past.

So I never gave them the chance to ask.

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"You know me better than my wife at this point. It's time for you to move on."

Chef said it like he was handing me a docket. Matter-of-fact. No ceremony. Just the truth, delivered the way kitchens deliver everything—fast, blunt, and with the assumption you'll figure out how to handle it.

Two and a half years.

Two and a half years of punishment in a room hotter than Satan's arsehole, with fluorescent lights that made everyone look like they were already dead, and a sous chef whose entire purpose on this earth seemed to be making sure I understood—daily, hourly, by the fucking minute—that I wasn't good enough yet.

And now, apparently, I was.

CDP.

Chef de Partie. My own section. Responsibility that actually meant something.

Three and a half years earlier, I'd been living a different life entirely. The kind that doesn't go on a résumé. The kind that ends in one of two places, and neither of them involves a starched apron and a nine-inch Wüsthof.

Everyone in that kitchen was blissfully unaware of who I was... who I used to be?

Except Fat Sam.

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Fat Sam found out about three months after I started. I never asked how. Didn't matter. The moment he knew, something shifted—not in how he treated me, but in *why*.

See, Sam was trained in the days before HR sanitised the industry. Back when kitchens were built on fear and repetition and a kind of violence that was considered educational. He was Chef's enforcer. Built like a commercial freezer and twice as cold. For a man that size, he was disturbingly quiet—you'd swear the floorboards should've groaned under him, but they never did. He just appeared. Materialised at your shoulder the exact moment your knife slipped or your timing went to shit.

And once he knew my history?

He rode me harder than anyone else on the line.

At first, I thought it was a power play. Some fucked-up territorial nonsense. Here's the guy with a past, let's see how long until he snaps.

It took me a long time to realise it wasn't that at all.

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There was one afternoon—middle of prep, the kind of day where the air is already thick and the first ticket hasn't even dropped yet—and Sam was on me about something. I don't even remember what. Could've been my knife work. Could've been how I was storing the mise. Could've been the way I was fucking breathing.

Didn't matter.

What mattered was the feeling building in my chest. That old, familiar heat. The one I used to let out whenever someone pushed too hard, said the wrong thing, looked at me in a way that my old brain interpreted as *threat*.

Three and a half years earlier, this moment would've ended differently.

Three and a half years earlier, I wouldn't have let a bloke talk to me like this for more than a sentence before reminding him—physically, permanently—that I wasn't someone whose patience you tested.

Temper climbing. Vision narrowing. That old operating system booting up like it had never been switched off.

Mid-bollocking, I turned.

Looked him dead in the eye.

"Watch your fucken mouth before I stab you, cunt."

The kitchen didn't stop. That's the thing. Pans kept clanging. Someone was breaking down a fish two benches over. The extractor fan hummed its endless, indifferent hum. Nobody even glanced our way.

Sam didn't flinch.

Didn't blink.

Just held my eyes like he'd been waiting for this exact moment since the day he found out who I was.

"Go home," he said.

"Get fucked. I've got shit to do before service."

"Then go for a cigarette. Now. Cool off."

"I said I've got—"

"Cigarette. *Now.*"

We stayed like that for a beat. Maybe two. Eyes locked, neither of us giving an inch—but something in the air had shifted. There was no anger in his voice. No fear either. Just... understanding.

Like he'd seen this movie before.

Like maybe, a long time ago, he'd been the one standing where I was standing.

The rest of the brigade carried on around us. Oblivious or indifferent, I couldn't tell. Maybe both.

I wasn't about to go home. Call it stubbornness. Call it a sadistic attachment to the punishment. Call it not knowing how to walk away from something I'd actually chosen, for once in my miserable life.

But I went outside for a smoke anyway.

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The alley behind that kitchen smelled like grease traps and old cardboard. I leaned against the wall, lit a cigarette, and tried to figure out what the fuck had just happened.

I'd threatened to stab a man.

In a room full of witnesses.

And instead of firing me, calling the cops, or putting me through a wall, he'd told me to take a break.

That's when it started to click.

Sam wasn't riding me because he wanted to break me. He was riding me because he knew—better than anyone—what I was capable of becoming if someone didn't. The version of me that walked into that kitchen wasn't built for this industry. Wasn't built for anything legal, really. And every time he pushed, every time he tested the edges of my patience, he was teaching me something I'd never learned anywhere else.

How to take it.

How to turn that heat into fuel instead of fire.

How to stay in the room when every instinct screams *leave* or *destroy*.

I finished the cigarette. Went back inside. Found Sam at his station, not even looking up.

I didn't apologise. He didn't expect one.

We just got back to work.